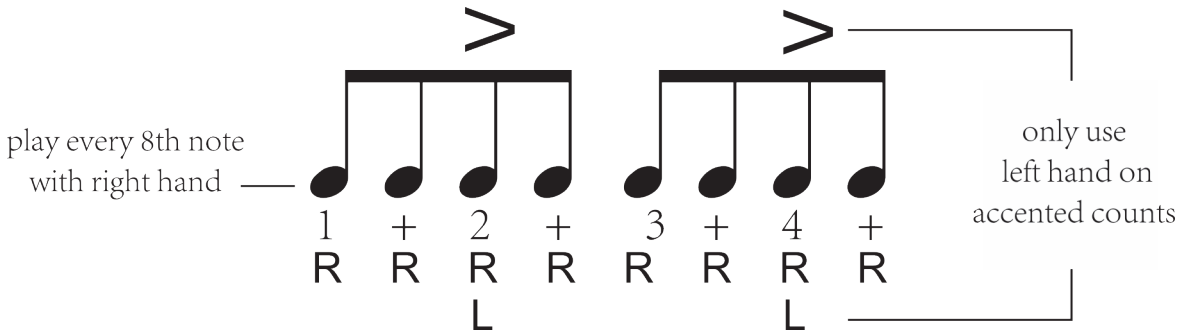
LESSON 5: USING YOUR HANDS

Internalizing rhythmic concepts is much easier when we don't have to focus on notes, chords, or strums. Tapping our hands and feet is superb way to start developing an internal clock that can tick away subconsciously while we play our instrument.

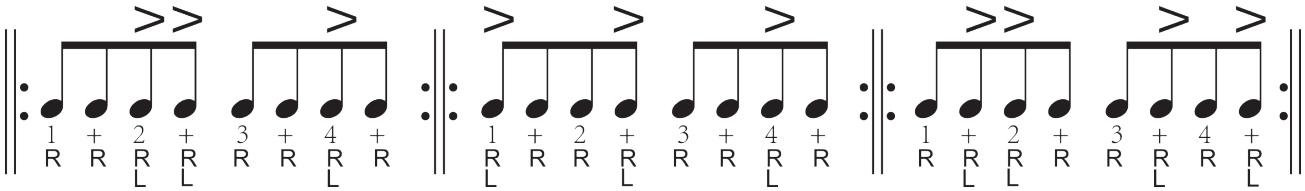
To begin, use your right hand (R) to tap steady eighth notes while counting them all out loud (*"one and two and three and four and"*). Say the accented counts louder than the surrounding ones. On those accented counts, also tap your left hand (so both hands tap together.)

Once you're comfortable with this exercise at a slow tempo, reverse your hands so that the left hand plays steady eighth notes while the right hand only comes in on the accents.



The pattern you've just learned is popular amongst rock drummers, where their right hand plays steady eighth notes on the hi-hat while their left hand plays the **backbeat** (the 2 and 4 beat) on the snare.

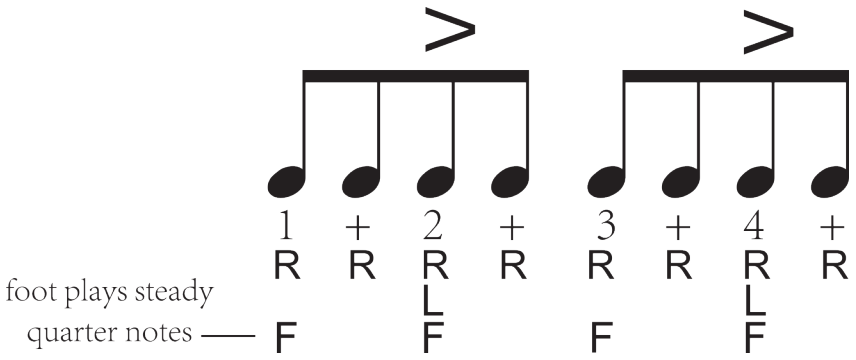
Here are some more classic rhythm patterns that translate well to the drum set. Practice each measure on a loop, count every eighth note out loud, and say the accented counts even louder.



Once you've mastered these patterns, try them again with your hands reversed.

Adding the Foot

Drummers often play steady quarter notes on their kick drum. We'll emulate this by tapping our foot on each downbeat. Here's that first exercise again, now with the foot included:



It's a good idea to break this down step-by-step and perform it very slowly until the pattern sets in:

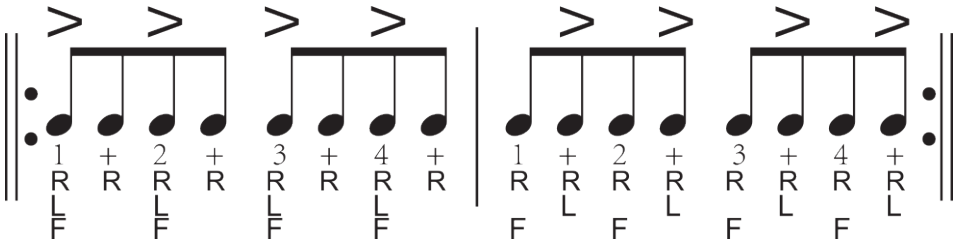
1. Tap your right hand and your foot together.
2. Tap just your right hand
3. Tap everything together (right hand, left hand, and foot)
4. Tap just your right hand

After that, the four steps repeat.

Upbeats (Syncopation) vs. Downbeats

Count each eighth note out loud while tapping your foot on the quarter notes, and say the accented counts out loud. Pay close attention to the "feel" of upbeats as they click in between your downbeats.

Be careful on the repeat: you'll have to tap your left hand twice in a row, on the final upbeat and also on the upcoming 1 beat after it.



Try all of this lesson's exercises using the following practice method instead:

1. Clap your hands together on every single eighth note.
2. Tap your foot on the downbeats only (1 2 3 4)
3. Only say the accented counts out loud and remain silent for the others.